



Course Title:	SP 101 Social and Professional Issues
Course Description:	This course discusses the ethical challenges in Information Technology education. It discusses the ethical implications and societal impacts of their profession as well as the threats against, and defenses needed for performance and security in information technology. It helps students in making professional decisions when faced with a problem in their workplace that raises a moral issue.
Units / Credits Equivalent:	3 Units
Pre-Requisite:	3rd Year Standing
Course Outcomes:	CO1: Compose a reflection paper about the possible social, ethical, legal, and professional issues that the proposed capstone project might encounter.
Learning Outcomes:	LO1: Argue the pros and cons of the design and implementation of computing solutions in various organizations. LO2: Analyze ethical and legal issues that arise in the information field to determine how to address them technically and ethically.

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SP 101 SOCIAL AND PROFESSIONAL ISSUES
STUDY GUIDE
Unit 1: Common Ethical Theories
Lesson 1: Relativism and Divine Command Theory

Introduction

In the field of ethical theories, Relativism and Divine Command Theory offer distinct perspectives on moral decision-making. Relativism posits that moral principles are not absolute but vary depending on cultural, societal, or individual contexts. This approach emphasizes understanding and tolerance of different moral viewpoints, which is crucial for BSIT students as they navigate diverse global environments and work with various stakeholders. On the other hand, Divine Command Theory asserts that moral standards are grounded in the commands of a divine being, offering a fixed and absolute foundation for ethical behavior. Understanding these theories helps students analyze and address ethical issues in the tech field, considering both flexible and rigid moral frameworks.

For BSIT students, grasping these ethical theories is essential for developing a comprehensive approach to evaluating the pros and cons of computing solutions and understanding the ethical and legal issues in the information field. By comparing and contrasting Relativism and Divine Command Theory, students can better appreciate the complexities of ethical decision-making in technology. This knowledge not only enhances their ability to discuss and differentiate between various ethical theories but also prepares them to implement and advocate for ethical practices in their professional careers.

1. How can Relativism and Divine Command Theory be applied to ethical dilemmas in the tech industry, such as data privacy and cybersecurity?

2. In what ways could Divine Command Theory provide a framework for addressing ethical and legal issues in the information field, and how can IT professionals balance this with the need for flexibility and cultural sensitivity in their work?

I know that you are very excited to discover new things, but before anything else, let us identify the competencies you may acquire this week.



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Learning Objectives

At the end of the term, you will be able to:

LO1: Argue the pros and cons of the design and implementation of computing solutions in various organizations.

LO2: Analyze ethical and legal issues that arise in the information field to determine how to address them technically and ethically.

Intended Learning Outcomes

At the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

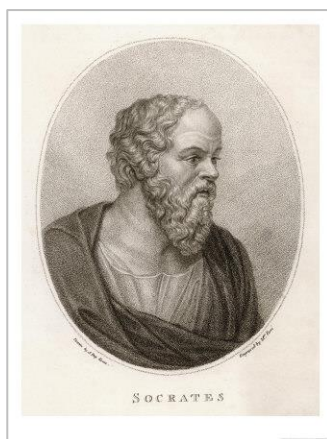
Discuss and differentiate the different ethical theories.

At this point, we will now start the actual lesson. Just enjoy the ride, and I hope you will learn a lot.

Key Concepts

Relativism and Divine Command Theory

The formal study of ethics goes back at least two thousand four hundred (2,400) years, to the Greek philosopher Socrates. In the past two millennia, philosophers have proposed many ethical theories.



Socrates

In this chapter, we review some of them. How do we decide if a particular theory is useful?

A useful theory allows its proponents to examine moral problems, reach conclusions, and defend these conclusions in front of a disbelieving, yet open-minded audience.

The term '**ethics**' broadly describes the way in which we look at and understand life, in terms of good and bad or right and wrong. It is a branch of knowledge that deals with moral principles. Moral theories are the frameworks we use to justify or clarify our position when we ask ourselves "*what should I do in this situation?*" or "*what is right or wrong for me?*" There are many moral theories and there is no one right theory. They converge and often borrow from one another (Wallace, Susan).



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Relativism

Relativism is the theory of no universal moral norm of right and wrong. According to this theory, different individuals or groups of people can have completely opposite views of a moral problem, and both can be right.

Two particular kinds of relativism: **Subjective Relativism** and **Culture Relativism**.

Subjective Relativism

Each person decides right and wrong for himself/herself. This notion is captured in the popular expression "*What's right for you may not be right for me.*"

Subjectivism is grounded on the claim that knowledge is exceptionally judgmental intrinsically, and there is no universal, external or objective truth that is not viewed through personal perceptions. It entails in subjectivism's statement that a human's attitude toward morality depends strictly on the mental judgment of events occurring around an individual. Therefore, morality is subjective and personal that makes it impossible to condemn a person for their actions.

The Case for Subjective Relativism

Well-meaning and intelligent people can have totally opposite opinions about moral issues.

For example:

Consider the issue of Reproductive Health (RH) law in our country. There are significant numbers of rational people who cannot reach the same conclusion that morality is not like gravity; it is not something "out there" that rational people can discover and try to understand. Instead, each of us creates his or her own morality. When faced with a difficult moral problem, who is to say which side is correct? If morality is relative, we do not have to try to reconcile opposing views. Both sides are right.

Another case is the way professors treat their students:

Some, who are mostly education graduates, may be too kind and considerate to their students and they criticize some professors who manage to fail more than half of their students in a class. On the other hand, some professors, mostly Engineering, IT, and Law professors would fail their students if only two or three in a class pass. In this instance, each professor should respect the methodologies applied by others. The theory of relativism is applicable here.

The Case Versus Subjective Relativism

With subjective relativism, the line between doing what you think is right and doing what you want to do is not sharply drawn. People are good at rationalizing their bad behavior. Subjective relativism provides an ideal last line of defense for someone whose conduct is being questioned. When pressed to explain a decision or action, a subjective relativist can reply, "Who are you to tell me what I should



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and should not do?" If morality means doing whatever you want to do, it doesn't mean much, if it means anything at all.

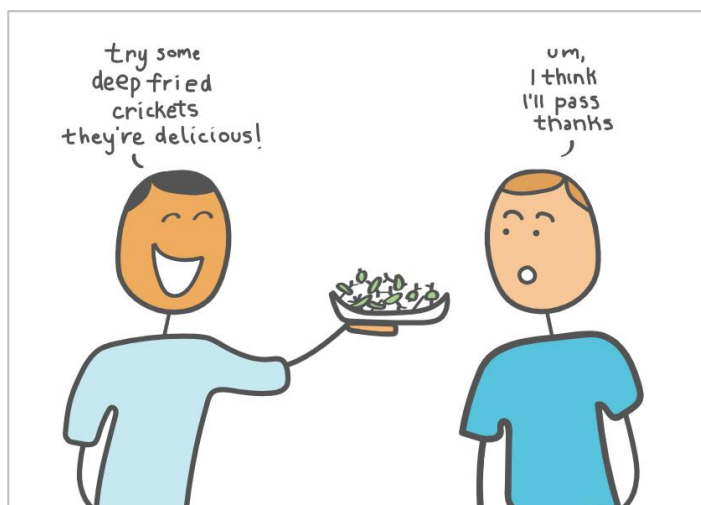
This ethical theory won't work on a patently morally wrong act.

Thus, if one believes that killing a corrupt government official is proper, and he did kill several officials, this theory will fall. Such an act is morally wrong because killing is unlawful/ illegal and is against public policy and public order. No amount of good reasoning can justify such an act.

Cultural Relativism

Cultural relativism is the ethical theory that the meaning of "right" and "wrong" rests with a society's actual moral guidelines. These guidelines vary widely from place to place and from time to time.

Have you ever seen or eaten food from another country, such as dried squid or fried crickets and think of it as weird and gross? This is an example of **ethnocentrism!** That means you use your own culture as the center and evaluate other cultures based on it. You are judging, or making assumptions about the food of other countries based on your own norms, values, or beliefs. Thinking "*dried squid is smelly*" or "*people shouldn't eat insects*" are examples of **ethnocentrism** in societies where people may not eat dried squid or insects.



Is ethnocentrism bad or good?

On the one hand, ethnocentrism can lead to negative judgments of the behaviors of groups or societies. It can also lead to discrimination against people who are different.

For example:

In many countries, religious minorities (religions that are not the dominant religion) often face discrimination.

But on the other hand, ethnocentrism can create loyalty among the same social group or people in the same society.



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For example:

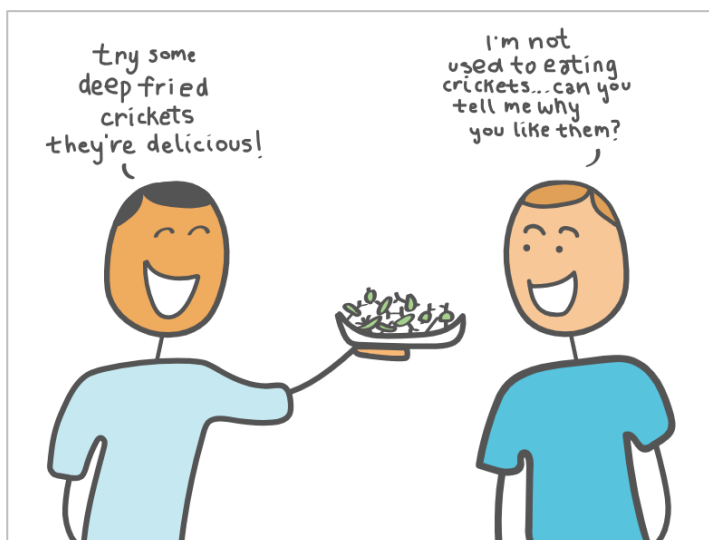
During the World Cup or Olympics, you may tend to root for your own country and believe that the players or teams representing your country are much better. National pride is also part of ethnocentrism.

To avoid judging the cultural practices of groups that are different to yours, we can use the *cultural relativism approach*.

Cultural relativism refers to not judging a culture to our own standards of what is right or wrong, strange or normal. Instead, we should try to understand cultural practices of other groups in its own cultural context.

For example:

Instead of thinking, "*Fried crickets are disgusting!*" one should instead ask, "*Why do some cultures eat fried insects?*". You may learn that fried crickets or grasshoppers are full of protein and in Mexico, it is famous Oaxaca regional cuisine and have been eaten for thousands of years as a healthy food source!



Some people worry that the concept of culture can also be abused and misinterpreted. If one culture behaves one way, does that mean all cultures can behave that way as well?

For example:

Many countries and international organizations oppose the act of whaling (the fishing of whales) for environmental reasons. These environmental organizations say that there are not many whales left and such fishing practices should be stopped. However, other countries argue that whaling is a cultural practice that has been around for thousands of years. Because it may be part of a country's oceanic culture, this country may say that such a cultural practice should not be opposed based on cultural differences, say, by an inland country that does not understand.

Who gets to define what a moral cultural behavior is? Is whaling immoral?

Two different cultures may have very different answers, as we saw in the above example. Another more extreme instance would be female genital cutting in some



parts of the world. Locally, it is argued that the practice has cultural roots, but such a practice has raised concerns among many international human rights organizations.

Anthropologists say that when we think about different cultures and societies, we should think about their customs in a way that helps us make sense of how their cultural practices fit within their overall cultural context.

For example:

Having several wives perhaps makes economic sense among herders who move around frequently. Through such an understanding, polygamy makes cultural sense.

Divine Command Theory

Divine Command Theory (DCT) is an ethical framework that posits that morality is grounded in the commands or will of a divine being. In this theory, **what is morally right is what God commands, and what is morally wrong is what God forbids**. This perspective suggests that ethical principles are not subjective or based on human reasoning but are instead derived from a higher, divine authority.

Concepts of Divine Command Theory

- **Moral Absolutism:** DCT supports the idea that certain actions are absolutely right or wrong, regardless of human opinions or cultural norms, because they are commanded by God.
- **Divine Authority:** The source of moral guidance is a divine being, whose commands are considered infallible and binding.
- **Moral Obligations:** Individuals have a duty to follow these divine commands to lead a morally upright life.

Examples:

Scenario	Divine Command Perspective	Discussion Points
Software Piracy	Belief that stealing, including intellectual property, is forbidden by divine command.	Is software piracy ethically wrong because it is a form of theft? How do religious beliefs influence views on software piracy?
Data Privacy and Confidentiality	Commands to respect others' privacy and confidentiality as an extension of "loving thy neighbor."	How do divine commands about respecting privacy shape our approach to data protection and confidentiality in IT?



Cyberbullying	View that harming others through cyberbullying is morally wrong because it violates principles of kindness and respect.	How do religious teachings against harm and for kindness influence policies and actions against cyberbullying?
Inclusive Design	Promoting inclusivity and fairness as a reflection of divine commands to treat all individuals equally.	How can divine commands about equality and justice inspire more inclusive and fair design practices in technology?
Artificial Intelligence Ethics	Ethical AI development guided by divine principles of honesty, fairness, and not causing harm.	How can divine commands provide a moral framework for the development and implementation of ethical AI systems?

As a BSIT Student:

By incorporating Divine Command Theory into their ethical considerations, you can better understand how religious and moral beliefs influence decision-making in technology. This can lead to more ethically sound practices that respect diverse viewpoints and contribute to a more inclusive and fair technological landscape.

Understanding and discussing the implications of ethical theories in various IT scenarios can help students recognize the importance of integrating ethical principles into their professional lives, ensuring their actions align with both technical and moral standards.



Additional Learning Resources

To further explore this topic, let us watch this video.

BBC Ideas. (2019, June 6). Relativism: Is it wrong to judge other cultures? | A-Z of ISMs Episode 18 - BBC Ideas. [Video]. YouTube.

https://youtu.be/518FR6SbY_k?si=qutBOtxHfnO002Jn



Study Questions

I hope that you gained new knowledge from the key concepts. Shall we put that newly discovered information to the test by answering the questions below? `

- What is the central concept of moral relativism, as explained in the video?

- If we strive to understand other cultures, does that necessarily mean we have to accept their moral practices, even if they differ from our own? Explain your answer.

- Think of a situation where cultural practices might clash with widely held moral values. How can we approach such situations while considering both cultural sensitivity and ethical principles?

Great job! After learning the key concepts, I am sure that you are now ready to answer your worksheets. You can do it!



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Learning Activities

WEEK 1 ASSESSMENT	TITLE: Identifying Subjective Relativism and Cultural Relativism
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	Course Title:	
	Instructor:	
	Student Name:	
	Course:	
	Year:	
	Date Submitted:	

Please read the instructions carefully and consult with the instructional coach if you have any questions. Deadlines in the VLE will not be extended.

Date of Submission:

Instructions:

1. Read each scenario and determine if it illustrates subjective relativism, cultural relativism, or neither.
2. Select the best answer for each scenario from the options provided.
3. Answer the assessment in the VLE.



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Summary

Subjective and Cultural Relativism are two ethical theories that challenge the notion of universal moral principles. Subjective Relativism posits that moral judgments are based on individual perspectives, meaning what is right or wrong varies from person to person. Cultural Relativism, on the other hand, argues that moral standards are determined by cultural context, implying that what is considered ethical in one society may not be in another. For BSIT students, understanding these theories is crucial in navigating the diverse and global nature of the IT field.

The Divine Command Theory is a moral theory that asserts that an act is morally right if it is commanded or approved by God, and that an act is morally wrong if it is forbidden or disapproved by God. Its proponents claim that God's commands provide an objective and clear standard for morality, but critics raise concerns about the arbitrariness of God's commands and the relationship between morality and religion.

By recognizing that ethical norms can differ significantly across individuals and cultures, students can develop a more nuanced approach to ethical decision-making and appreciate the importance of cultural sensitivity in their professional practices. This understanding helps in differentiating and discussing various ethical theories, aligning with the course's intended learning outcomes.

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